Traditional Chinese Medicine at Tong Keow Healthcare

Everyday care convenience local adaptation and pattern differentiation

GEC1044 Group Fieldwork Report

TD3 Group 2
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1 Introduction

At Tong Keow's Hougang outlet, herbs and packaged soups are sold alongside everyday foods. Staff described purchases for nourishment, throat comfort, fatigue and needs linked to daily routines. These displays and staff accounts show how Traditional Chinese Medicine (TCM) fits into ordinary shopping and cooking. This is the focus of our report.

We argue that Tong Keow helps keep TCM in use by fitting traditional ingredients and products into everyday household habits. Section 3 explains how food gives herbs a familiar purpose. Section 4 looks at how prepared products make them easier to use. Section 5 considers how the products fit Singapore's production, rules and cultural setting. Section 6 brings these findings together and explains why treatment needs an assessment of each person. Appendix A keeps the detailed survey findings.

2 Fieldwork and the neighbourhood medicine hall

2.1 How we conducted the fieldwork

We visited Tong Keow on 13 September 2026, photographed the displays and interviewed one staff member. This report uses the transcripts, presentation script and photographs. Where the transcripts contain errors, we restate the clear meaning in our own words. All staff accounts in this report come from this interview.

We distinguish what the staff member said from what our photographs show. We also make clear when we offer our own interpretation. Published sources provide historical and industry context, and course concepts guide our discussion. Descriptions of popular and lower-demand products reflect the staff member's retail experience.

2.2 Tong Keow and its mixed retail model

Tong Keow Medical Hall is an established TCM shop and clinic with roots in Toa Payoh. Its company profile states that it was founded in 1968 and is now run by the second generation of family owners. It sells raw herbs, such as American ginseng and monk fruit, as well as cooling teas,

pills and medicinal plasters. This range brings traditional herbs together with products for everyday care (Tong Keow Medical Hall, 2022; “Instagram Reel About Tong Keow Medical Hall,” n.d.).

The company also advertises consultations with registered TCM physicians, acupuncture and cupping for concerns such as indigestion, common colds and joint sprains (“Instagram Reel About Tong Keow Medical Hall,” n.d.). These services are part of the wider business’s advertised clinical role. Our Hougang visit focused on retail displays and staff accounts. We did not record a consultation or clinical prescription.

Our photographs show branded soup packs alongside herbs, grains and other foods. The branding links the branch to the wider business. We see this mixed range as an important part of the shop’s everyday role because shoppers can come across herbal products during an ordinary trip to buy food.

2.3 Hougang and the customers described by staff

Staff described customers as mainly Chinese, middle-aged and older, including people in their forties and fifties. Hougang planning area had 228,140 residents in June 2024. HDB separately reported 57,557 dwelling units and 165,450 residents in its Hougang flats at 31 March 2024. These totals cover different housing populations (DOS, 2024; Housing & Development Board [HDB], 2024, pp. 11–12).

Hougang Central, the subzone around the outlet, had about 4,620 residents in June 2025. Official rounded age-group totals show that around 1,070 residents were aged 65 or above, or roughly 23% (DOS, 2025). This sizeable older population gives context to the customers described by staff and the shop’s range of household foods and nourishment products.

The 647 Hougang respondents in Chua et al.’s (2025) study had an average age of 69 and had lived in the area for an average of 22 years. Seventeen per cent lived alone, compared with 15% of the 552 Taman Jurong respondents. This difference was not statistically significant. Their long period of residence is relevant to our report because it places the medicine hall in an established community with regular household shopping and care routines.

Hougang’s Teochew history gives more context. The National Heritage Board describes the community around Tou Mu Kung and its fishing, farming and rubber-growing activities (National Heritage Board [NHB], n.d.). We see this history and residential setting as background for the shop’s mixed range of medicinal products and foods. The account of its current customers comes from staff.

3 Everyday care and food therapy

3.1 Herbs in household meals

Staff named Dang Shen, Huang Qi, Yu Zhu, Huai Shan, red dates and goji as common soup ingredients. The presentation included ginseng/American ginseng and monk fruit among its eight herb entries. Table A1 lists the two ginseng profiles separately. The prepared packs and family cooking image show how these ingredients fit into household meals (Figures 1–2).

Soup gives herbs a familiar household purpose. Lecture 5 describes Chinese medicine as a cultural framework that shapes everyday food and health habits. This helps us understand the display through the ideas of nourishing life (养生) and medicine and food sharing a source (药食同源). Lim

et al. (2005) identify health maintenance as an important reason for use, and Yang (2022) places medicine within changing community life. Our fieldwork shows one way this happens: herbs enter the household through cooking.

3.2 Soup packs and light nourishment

The presentation grouped soups under five labels: Qing Bu Liang (清补凉), Dang Shen–Huang Qi soup (党参北芪补气汤), Yu Zhu–Huai Shan soup (玉竹淮山润燥汤), goji–red date soup (枸杞红枣养生汤) and Five Finger Fig soup (五指毛桃健脾汤). Table A4 records the named ingredients and links familiar preparations to specific forms of care. Staff linked these soups to digestion, moistening and light nourishment (清补). Light nourishment offers an everyday option alongside stronger tonification (大补). Named packs make these ideas easier to use because buyers can take them home to cook. In TCM, the Spleen and Liver refer to broader functional systems, not just physical organs. These systems help explain how light nourishment formulas are understood to support digestion and metabolic balance (World Health Organization [WHO], 2022). We see the packs as a way of bringing these ideas into meals.

3.3 Singapore weather and the appeal of lighter soups

Staff linked the popularity of monk fruit and lighter soups to Singapore's environment. Meteorological Service Singapore describes high temperatures, heavy rainfall and humidity throughout the year, with monsoon and inter-monsoon periods (Meteorological Service Singapore [MSS], n.d.). This gives context to the presentation's phrase "without four distinct seasons" and the staff account of local demand.

The Suwen (素问) reading links seasonal habits to maintaining health (Unschuld & Tessenow, 2011, pp. 45–57). We see the staff's discussion of lighter soups as retail advice that takes the environment into account. Singapore's weather helps explain their appeal. The ingredient profiles add detail. For example, Yu Zhu (玉竹) is linked to moistening dryness. The climate gives context to the staff account, and each named ingredient keeps its specific TCM function.

4 Convenience and changing ways of using products

4.1 Easier preparation for younger buyers

Staff described younger customers as buying fewer raw herbs and preferring teas, supplements and simpler preparations. Table A2 keeps the eight presentation categories, including ginseng tonics, herbal teas, soup packs, mood-support products and medicated oils. This account highlights product form because staff link easier preparation to younger customers' routines.

Soup packs show how products meet this preference for convenience. The ingredients are already selected and portioned, so households can skip the initial preparation of raw herbs and start cooking. Staff explain the intended use of specific ingredients, and buyers finish preparing the soup at home. Finished capsules need even less effort. The photographed multi-buy promotion also presents soup packs through a familiar supermarket offer. We see convenience as a change in how the work is shared between the seller and the household. The shop takes on more of the selection and preparation, making traditional ingredients easier to choose and use in daily routines.

4.2 Comparative industry examples

Industry examples show planned changes in how herbal products are sold. Nanyang Polytechnic describes Heng Foh Tong's redesign of herbal drinks for millennials (Nanyang Polytechnic [NYP], n.d.). Amacha markets TCM-inspired milk teas, and a founder interview reported more than 150,000 cups sold in eight months (Amacha, n.d.; Angelynn T., 2026). Teck Soon's owner reported a 30% increase in sales after moving herbs from drawers to storefront displays in 1982 (Chin, 2024). These sources are promotional, news or institutional public-relations accounts, rather than peer-reviewed studies. They are useful because they describe specific ways of changing product forms and making herbs easier to find. They give context to Tong Keow's prepared packs and the staff account of convenience.





Figure 4.2a. Heng Foh Tong herbal-drink vending machine. Bottled drinks and self-service purchasing illustrate how herbal products can be presented in a convenient retail format, linking the industry example to Tong Keow's emphasis on easier preparation and use.

Figure 4.2b. Amacha branded takeaway drinks. The shop setting and takeaway cups illustrate a contemporary beverage format for the TCM-inspired teas discussed above, showing how traditional ingredients can be marketed through familiar consumer routines.



Figure 4.2c. Herbal retailing with a traditional balance scale and visible ingredient jars. The photograph illustrates the weighing and display of raw herbs, providing a visual comparison with bottled and takeaway drinks. Making ingredients visible can help customers see what is available, as discussed in the Teck Soon example.

4.3 Products for daily pressures

Staff linked daily pressures, such as late nights, long work hours and long periods of phone use, to demand for liver-care or mood-support products. Products described as soothing Liver-related constraint (疏肝解郁) show how this retail language connects traditional treatment terms with concerns about modern lifestyles.

A survey gives wider context to this retail language. In a report on ADP's 2023 survey, Kumari (2024) states that 68% of Singapore workers experienced work-related stress at least weekly, compared with 61% across the surveyed Asia-Pacific markets. Twelve per cent reported daily stress. These findings give context to the staff's descriptions of daily pressures. We see the shop's product language as connecting TCM to familiar concerns and routines. This supports our argument that traditional products take on new everyday uses as they adapt.

4.4 Preparation effort and lower-demand products

Lower-demand examples also help explain the appeal of simpler products. The presentation listed three examples described by staff: Ban Zhi Lian (半枝莲), specialist herbs that need to be combined, and strong tonic formulas (大补方) (Table A5). Staff linked their lower appeal to unfamiliarity and preparation effort. The presentation also discussed how suitable stronger tonic formulas are for Singapore's climate. Staff said items that sold more slowly were stocked in smaller quantities. We understand these accounts as showing a link between a product's display and stock levels and the explanation and preparation it needs. This helps explain the appeal of prepared packs, which leave selection and portioning to the shop.

5 Local adaptation through products packaging and cultural contact

5.1 Imported materials and locally made products

Lecture 5 describes localisation as adaptation to climate, available materials and society. At Tong Keow, this appears at several stages of production. Staff said most imports came from China because of variety and cost, and local cultivation was limited. The presentation kept five examples: cactus (仙人掌), roselle (洛神花), patent medicines, Five Flower Tea (五花茶) and monk-fruit tea (罗汉果茶) (Table A3).

Branded packs also give herbs a recognisable retail form. Staff described local processing and packing. Our interpretation focuses on the visible selection and portioning of ingredients, named uses and local branding. Packaging shapes how shoppers see and use the product. Table A3 separates cultivation, manufacture and packaging to make each example's link to Singapore clear.

The local manufacture and assembly of finished Chinese Proprietary Medicines (CPM) are regulated parts of Singapore's supply chain. The Health Sciences Authority (HSA) requires the relevant dealer licences and product listing. Facilities must also meet licensing and Good Manufacturing Practice requirements (HSA, 2026c, 2026d). The capsule example links the shop's products to this framework. Raw herbs, foods and soup packs fall under their own product categories.

5.2 Packaging and the language of trust

Packaging identifies a product's contents and source. HSA's CPM guidelines require full English labelling and matching information in any additional languages. They also require product and

ingredient details, batch and expiry information, and the relevant manufacturer, importer or assembler details (HSA, 2025a, section 5). These rules shape the information shoppers see on the box. Product listing is separate from an assessment of treatment effectiveness (HSA, 2026b). This difference matters when reading health claims.

Quality labels are another way of communicating with shoppers. Staff stressed fresh colour and sulphur-free materials. Our photograph shows a sulphur-free Dang Shen label and a separate American ginseng label (Figure 3). We see these claims about quality and identity as ways of encouraging trust in the shop's products. HSA warns that "natural" does not guarantee safety (HSA, 2026a), so these labels need to be read with care. We expect these practices to attract younger customers by reassuring them about product quality and addressing concerns about possible side effects.

5.3 Different shoppers in a shared space

Staff reported that most customers were Chinese, but Malay customers came to buy dessert ingredients and Indian customers came to buy nuts. These everyday purchases give different communities familiar reasons to enter the same medicine hall. Eu Yan Sang offers a useful comparison because its halal product category shows how a business can meet different customers' needs (Eu Yan Sang, n.d.). The Tong Keow account shows another way of reaching different communities through ordinary food shopping.

Lecture 5's discussion of senna helps explain this. It shows that the same plant can have different meanings in Chinese and Malay medicine. This idea also applies to Tong Keow's shared shopping space, where customers may buy the same goods for different habits and purposes. So we see the staff account of dessert ingredients and nuts as an example of cultural contact through everyday purchases. The shop can become familiar to different communities, and each community can understand its products in its own way. This links the course discussion to the shopping routines described in our fieldwork.

6 Bringing the findings together through pattern differentiation and adaptation

6.1 Retail advice and pattern differentiation

Table A1 describes ginseng as neutral and American ginseng as cool and Yin-nourishing. These different profiles show why each person needs an individual assessment. The staff's link between fatigue and tonic use in Table A6 gives a starting point for discussion. But choosing between these herbs for treatment requires a fuller assessment of signs and symptoms through pattern differentiation and treatment (辨证论治) (WHO, 2022). This connects to Lecture 5's comparison of treatment for cold-damage and warm-disease patterns. The ginseng example makes the principle clear: the right choice depends on the person's full pattern of signs and symptoms.

These clinical differences also sit within a wider setting where people use more than one form of care. MOH reported that nearly 40% of TCM users in the 2022 National Population Health Survey used TCM and Western medicine for the same condition (Ministry of Health [MOH], 2025). This national finding gives context to the medicine hall's everyday role. Buying products for nourishment or household care may be one part of a person's wider health routine.

6.2 How the shop brings TCM into everyday life

The findings show how several features work together to make TCM accessible. Food gives herbs a household purpose, prepared packs reduce selection and preparation effort, and packaging explains uses. Local branding and manufacture link products to Singapore's retail setting and rules. We see these features as practical ways of bringing traditional ingredients and products into everyday use.

The mixed shop brings these activities into one place. Branding links the branch to a wider business, and Hougang's population gives context to the customers described by staff. These features help explain how the products on its shelves fit household routines. The shop's everyday role depends on its products, preparation methods and location.

Unschuld's (2018) account of adaptation and Yang's (2022) history help explain these links. Unschuld argues that Chinese medicine has always changed with its social and political environment. Yang shows that TCM in Singapore became more modern, more formally organised and more locally adapted through the influence of the state, medical professionals and religious organisations. These accounts suggest that the shop's retail practices are part of a longer history of TCM adapting to local conditions, as well as business strategies. Our fieldwork brings this discussion into retail. Traditional ingredients gain practical household uses through familiar foods and prepared products. A neighbourhood shop helps keep them in use through the way it arranges, explains and sells them.

7 Limitations

The report is based on one visit and one staff interview. Accounts of demand, preferences and purchases by different communities come from staff. Sales records, customer interviews and comparisons with other branches would help us assess these accounts more fully. Neighbourhood statistics describe the surrounding population, and industry examples provide comparisons.

We did not have complete soup recipes or sourcing and purchasing records. The pictured Nature's Green capsules have a confirmed link to manufacture in Singapore, but their ingredient origins remain unknown. Staff named the product category rather than the brand. It was unclear whether a physician was present, and we recorded no consultation, prescription or patient outcome. MOH (2026) provides wider context on professional registration.

The appendix separates reference profiles and external images from field photographs. Customer interviews and further visits would help us develop this account.

8 Conclusion

Tong Keow makes TCM available through food, prepared products and a medicine hall that sells a mixed range of goods. Soup displays link herbs to cooking and light nourishment. Prepared packs leave selection and portioning to the seller, so households can start with cooking. Local branding and manufacture place some products within Singapore's retail setting. The food range also gives different communities familiar reasons to enter. Together, the displays and staff accounts support our argument that traditional ingredients and products gain everyday uses as they adapt.

The Hougang shop shows how adaptation can help keep TCM in use. Food gives herbs a household purpose, convenience reduces the work involved, and local adaptation gives products a recognisable form. These retail changes create opportunities for people of different races, religions and ages to encounter TCM. Choosing treatment still requires an assessment of the person's

pattern of signs and symptoms. So the shop’s role in making products approachable and the clinical work of assessing each person are separate parts of the wider practice of care.

Appendix A Detailed fieldwork evidence

Appendix A keeps the detailed survey findings from the group presentation. The tables identify uses reported by staff, traditional reference profiles and photograph sources.

A1 Eight herb entries with separate reference profiles

The presentation groups ginseng and American ginseng as one entry. Table A1 lists their profiles separately, so it has nine rows for the eight reported entries. The field cabinet also labels American ginseng separately.

Table A1 Traditional herb profiles in the eight presentation entries

Herb	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 人参 *Ren Shen* Ginseng (root) (PolyU, n.d.-h)	Sweet, slightly bitter; neutral	Heart, Spleen, Lung	Strongly tonifies original Qi; supports Spleen and Lung; generates fluids; calms the spirit.	Poor appetite, fatigue and breathlessness in Qi-deficiency patterns; thirst from fluid depletion.
 西洋参 *Xi Yang Shen* American ginseng (root) (PolyU, n.d.-a)	Sweet, slightly bitter; cool	Heart, Lung, Kidney	Tonifies Qi and nourishes Yin; clears heat; generates fluids.	Fatigue, dry mouth, thirst and cough in Qi–Yin deficiency with deficiency heat.
 党参 *Dang Shen* Codonopsis (root) (PolyU, n.d.-m)	Sweet; neutral	Spleen, Lung	Tonifies middle Qi; strengthens Spleen and Lung functions.	Poor appetite, loose stools, fatigue and shortness of breath in Spleen–Lung Qi deficiency.

Herb	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 黄芪 *Huang Qi* Astragalus / milkvetch (root) (PolyU, n.d.-l)	Sweet; warm	Spleen, Lung	Tonifies Qi; strengthens exterior defence; promotes fluid discharge and tissue repair.	Fatigue, poor appetite and loose stools in Qi deficiency; spontaneous sweating from weak exterior defence.
 玉竹 *Yu Zhu* Fragrant Solomon's seal (rhizome) (PolyU, n.d.-g)	Sweet; slightly cold	Lung, Stomach	Nourishes Yin; moistens dryness; generates fluids and relieves thirst.	Dry cough, dry throat and thirst in Lung–Stomach Yin deficiency.
 淮山 / 山药 *Huai Shan / Shan Yao* Chinese yam (rhizome) (PolyU, n.d.-f)	Sweet; neutral	Spleen, Lung, Kidney	Supports Spleen and Stomach; generates fluids and benefits Lung; strengthens Kidney.	Poor appetite and persistent diarrhoea in Spleen deficiency; chronic cough in Lung deficiency; frequent urination in Kidney deficiency.
 红枣 / 大枣 *Hong Zao / Da Zao* Red dates / jujube (fruit) (PolyU, n.d.-d)	Sweet; warm	Spleen, Stomach	Tonifies middle Qi; nourishes Blood; calms the spirit.	Poor appetite, tiredness and loose stools in Spleen-deficiency patterns.

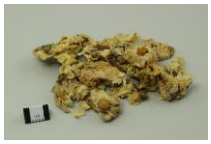
Herb	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 枸杞子 *Gou Qi Zi* Goji / wolfberry (fruit) (PolyU, n.d.-b)	Sweet; neutral	Liver, Kidney	Nourishes Liver and Kidney; replenishes essence; supports vision.	Dizziness, aching lower back and knees, and impaired vision in Liver–Kidney deficiency patterns.
 罗汉果 *Luo Han Guo* Monk fruit (fruit) (PolyU, n.d.-j)	Sweet; cool	Lung, Large Intestine	Clears heat; moistens Lung; lubricates the intestines.	Dry cough, sore throat and hoarseness in Lung-heat dryness; constipation from intestinal dryness.

Note. Herb photographs and traditional profiles are adapted from the Hong Kong Polytechnic University database (PolyU). Meridian names refer to TCM functional systems, and the applications describe traditional uses in their stated contexts.

A2 Eight reported product categories with illustrations

The eight categories follow presentation slide 4. The supplied photograph identifies Nature's Green Mind Soothe Capsules as the example for liver care and mood support. Details of mixtures and finished products are included where the field records provide them.

Table A2 Illustrated profiles of the eight presentation product categories

Product or category	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 **Ginseng tonics** 人参 / 西洋参	Varies by formula.	Not recorded.	Staff linked use to fatigue, Qi support and immunity.	Staff described use for fatigue and general nourishment.
 罗汉果 **Monk-fruit products** Reference material: monk fruit (PolyU, n.d.-j)	Reference fruit: sweet and cool.	Reference fruit: Lung and Large Intestine.	Staff associated it with throat comfort and cooling.	Fruit and drink forms were described, with recipes unrecorded.
 花茶 / 凉茶 **Flower and herbal teas** Reference flower: chrysanthemum (PolyU, n.d.-e)	Mixture not recorded.	Mixture not recorded.	Staff described everyday wellness uses.	Staff linked simple brewing to younger buyers.

Product or category	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 药材汤包 **Soup packs** Fieldwork soup display 13 September 2026	Complete recipe unknown.	Formula not recorded.	Presentation: light nourishment.	Preselected dried packs still require cooking.
 灵芝保健品 **Lingzhi supplements** Reference: Lingzhi (PolyU, n.d.-i)	Supplement formula not recorded.	Meridian links for the finished product were not recorded.	Staff associated supplements with immunity support.	Staff described use for general wellness and immunity support.
 养肝 / 疏肝解郁 Nature's Green 绿叶 Mind Soothe Capsules Supplied photograph	Formula not recorded.	Meridian links for the finished product were not recorded.	Staff described Liver nourishment and soothing constraint; the box uses "Mind Soothe" language.	Staff linked this category to late nights and stress.
 银翘类 **Yin Qiao-type remedies** Reference: honeysuckle (PolyU, n.d.-k)	Exact formula not identified.	Meridian links for the finished product were not recorded.	Staff associated this category with cold symptoms.	Staff described use for cold symptoms.

Product or category	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 红花油 / 红油精 **Medicated oils** External example (Fei Fah, n.d.)	Formula for external use not identified.	No meridian assigned.	Staff associated oils with aches and injuries.	Staff described external use, including by older customers.

Note. Uses follow the interview or presentation. The Nature's Green box is a supplied product photograph; the other reference illustrations are identified in their rows. Complete product formulas were not recorded during the visit.

A3 Five locally linked examples and production status

Table A3 separates local cultivation, manufacture and packaging. Nature's Green is the brand of the pictured Mind Soothe Capsules. HSA lists these capsules as a Singapore-manufactured Chinese Proprietary Medicine (HSA, 2025b). Their ingredient origins were not recorded.

Table A3 Locally linked examples retained from the presentation

Example	Raw origin and grown in Singapore	Manufacture in Singapore	Processing packaging or brand link
 **Cactus 仙人掌** (NParks, n.d.-b)	Named as a possible locally grown example; origin of stock unknown	Not established	No specific product or producer identified.
 **Roselle 洛神花** (NParks, n.d.-a)	Named as a possible locally grown example; origin of stock unknown	Not established	No specific product or producer identified.
 **Mind Soothe Capsules 舒肝解郁胶囊** Nature's Green 绿叶 Finished CPM	Ingredient origins and Singapore cultivation are unverified.	HSA lists Tong Jum Chew as manufacturer and Singapore as the manufacturing country (HSA, 2025b).	Nature's Green is the brand of this finished Chinese Proprietary Medicine.
 **Five Flower Tea 五花茶** (Wing Joo Loong, n.d.)	Not established	Not established	Locally linked in the presentation; the processor, packer and brand of the specific item are unknown.

Example	Raw origin and grown in Singapore	Manufacture in Singapore	Processing packaging or brand link
 **Monk fruit tea** **罗汉果茶** Reference: monk fruit (PolyU, n.d.-j)	Not established for the tea product	Not established	Locally linked in the presentation; the processor, packer and brand of the specific item are unknown.

Note. NParks supplies the reference plant photographs. The cactus species and stock origins were not identified in the interview. The Five Flower Tea image is an external product example, and the monk-fruit image shows a reference ingredient. HSA supplies the manufacturing information for the Nature’s Green capsules.

A4 Five soup therapies retained from the presentation

The five soup labels follow slide 6. Staff named Dang Shen, Huang Qi, Yu Zhu, Huai Shan, red dates and goji as common soup ingredients. Table A4 records the named ingredients and the presentation's descriptions of nourishment and everyday care.

Table A4 Soup labels ingredients and reported purposes

Soup label	Ingredients available from the record	Purpose and main use
 **Qing Bu Liang 清补凉** Field display context only	Complete recipe not recorded	Light nourishment and everyday care in the presentation.
 **Dang Shen and Huang Qi soup 党参北芪补气汤** Named ingredients only	Dang Shen and Huang Qi are named; complete recipe unknown	Qi support and nourishment in the presentation.
 **Yu Zhu and Huai Shan soup 玉竹淮山润燥汤** Named ingredients only	Yu Zhu and Huai Shan are named; complete recipe unknown	Moistening and nourishment in the presentation.
 **Goji and red date soup 枸杞红枣养生汤** Named ingredients only	Goji and red dates are named; complete recipe unknown	Everyday nourishment and health maintenance.
 **Five Finger Fig soup 五指毛桃健脾汤** Reference root only (DH, n.d.)	Five Finger Fig is named; other ingredients not recorded	Spleen and digestive support in traditional terms.

Note. Images show named materials, not complete formulas or finished soups. PolyU supplies Dang Shen, Huang Qi, Yu Zhu, Huai Shan, goji and red dates (n.d.-m, n.d.-l, n.d.-g, n.d.-f, n.d.-b, n.d.-d);

Hong Kong’s Department of Health (DH, n.d.) supplies Five Finger Fig root. The Qing Bu Liang image shows field display context only.

A5 Three comparatively lower-demand examples with illustrations

The lower-demand examples follow presentation slide 8: one named herb and two broader product categories. The descriptions come from staff and the presentation. They do not provide a numerical sales ranking.

Table A5 Illustrated profiles of the lower-demand examples

Product or category	Nature & Flavour	Meridian	Function	Application
 半枝莲 **Ban Zhi Lian Barbated skullcup herb** Reference material (PolyU, n.d.-c)	Sweet, bitter and cold.	Liver, Lung and Kidney.	Reference: clears heat and toxins, resolves stasis and promotes urination.	Reference uses include sores, throat swelling and oedema.
 **Specialist herbs** Requiring combinations	Varies by formula.	Varies by formula.	No combination was identified.	Staff described a need for preparation and guidance.
 大补方 **Strong tonic formulas** Tonic material illustration only (PolyU, n.d.-h)	Formula not recorded.	Formula not recorded.	Presentation: intensive replenishment 大补.	The presentation associated lower appeal with suitability and climate.

Note. Ban Zhi Lian properties come from PolyU. The specialist-herb photograph shows the field cabinet, and the ginseng image illustrates a tonic material. Specific combination and tonic formulas were not recorded.

A6 Staff-described product uses without confirmed clinical prescriptions

Staff described the six product associations below, which are kept from slide 9. It was unclear whether a physician was present at the outlet, and we recorded no clinical prescriptions or patient cases. So Table A6 presents retail descriptions from the interview.

Table A6 Staff-described product uses without confirmed clinical prescriptions

Complaint or wellness concern	Associated retail product	Clinical details not recorded
Colds	Yin Qiao type remedies	Formula and patient assessment not recorded.
Diarrhoea	Huoxiang Zhengqi type remedies	Formula and patient assessment not recorded.
Fatigue or Qi deficiency language	Ginseng or Dang Shen	Staff used fatigue and Qi-support language; no patient assessment recorded.
Perceived lower immunity	Lingzhi or supplements	Staff described immunity support; no patient assessment recorded.
Late nights stress and long work hours	Liver care or mood support products	Staff linked use to daily pressures; no diagnosis recorded.
Aches or injuries	Medicated oils	Staff described external use; no injury assessment recorded.

A7 Survey coverage and sources

Table A7 Survey coverage and details not recorded

Survey item	Record retained	Location	Details not recorded
A	Eight herb entries; nine reference profiles	A1; Section 3.1	No verified twelve-month sales ranking.
B	Eight product categories	A2; Section 4	Exact products and comparative sales unknown.
C	Five locally linked examples	A3; Section 5.1	Capsule manufacture confirmed; other origins not verified.
D	Five soup labels	A4; Section 3.2	Complete recipes and all pack identities unconfirmed.
E	One named herb and two categories	A5; Section 4.4	No verified ranking of the three lowest-selling products.
F	No physician prescriptions recorded	A6; Section 7	Physician role not confirmed; no clinical cases recorded.
G	Six separate retail associations	A6; Section 6.1	No physician-treated cases recorded.

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Appendix B Fieldwork photographs

Figure 1

Soup promotion in the neighbourhood retail setting



Note. Branded soup packs and a family cooking image at the shop frontage. Photograph by the group, Tong Keow Healthcare, 13 September 2026.

Figure 2

Preselected dried soup ingredients in branded packs



Note. Preselected dried ingredients in Tong Keow soup packs. Photograph by the group, Tong Keow Healthcare, 13 September 2026.

Figure 3

Herb labels and retail quality claims



Note. Cabinet labels for American ginseng and sulphur-free Dang Shen. Photograph by the group, Tong Keow Healthcare, 13 September 2026.